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A Psychological Study of the Impact of Cultural Barriers on Pastoral Counseling Effectiveness in Buguma City, Nigeria

Doctor of Philosophy in Psychology and Biblical Counseling

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AT A GLANCE

What this study is about

This study examined how cultural barriers affect the effectiveness of pastoral counseling in **Buguma City**, headquarters of Asari-Toru Local Government Area, Rivers State, Nigeria. Buguma is a major Kalabari settlement of 39 Polo, where pastoral care works within a communal worldview shaped by belief in ancestral influence, respect for elders and the authority of the Amanyanabo and Council of Chiefs.

407	51	38	6
questionnaires returned	churches surveyed	questionnaire items	chapters + 3 appendices

What the study found

- **Language and stigma stood out.** Language differences (M = 4.12) and cultural stigma (M = 4.07) were the barriers most strongly endorsed. Preference for tradition (M = 3.63) followed, and cultural beliefs and practices (M = 3.21) was the weakest.
- **Counseling was rated effective** overall (M = 4.15), with at least 98.5% agreement on every item.
- **Respondents backed solutions.** Strategies to mitigate the barriers received the highest agreement (M = 4.24). Training pastors in Kalabari language and culture ranked first (M = 4.29).
- **Two predictors mattered most.** The regression model was significant, $F(5, 401) = 10.95$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .120$. Only language differences ($\beta = .20$) and strategies ($\beta = .18$) were independent predictors.
- **An honest caution.** Two scales had low reliability, so findings on those two constructs are less secure.

What it recommends

- Kalabari language and cultural-competence training for pastors.
- Community psychoeducation to reduce stigma, and a guarantee of confidentiality.
- Culturally consistent involvement of family elders as partners.
- Referral networks between pastoral and clinical services.
- Combining biblical principles with cultural understanding.

The study at a glance

Design	Descriptive cross-sectional correlational survey
Setting	51 PFN- and CAN-affiliated churches in Buguma City, Rivers State
Population	About 5,000: 102 lead and assistant pastors and 4,898 adult members who had received counseling in the preceding 12 months
Sample	407: a census of all 102 pastors and 305 members chosen by proportionate stratified random selection
Instrument	CBPCEQ questionnaire: 38 items, seven sections, 5-point scale
Analysis	Frequencies, percentages, means, Pearson and Spearman correlations, multiple regression (0.05 level)

ABSTRACT

The full abstract

BACKGROUND AND THEORY

This study examined the impact of cultural barriers on pastoral counseling effectiveness in Buguma City, headquarters of Asari-Toru Local Government Area, Rivers State, Nigeria. Buguma is a major Kalabari settlement of 39 Polo, where pastoral care operates within a communal worldview shaped by belief in ancestral influence and Owuamapu (water-deity worship), respect for elders, and the authority of the Amanyanabo and Council of Chiefs. The study was anchored on Multicultural Counseling Theory, African Psychology, Social Cognitive Theory and Stigma Theory. Each theory was linked to specific study variables: cultural beliefs and practices, cultural stigma, preference for tradition, language differences, and strategies to mitigate the barriers, with pastoral counseling effectiveness as the outcome.

METHOD

A descriptive cross-sectional correlational survey was adopted. The estimated population was 5,000 (102 lead and assistant pastors and 4,898 adult members who had received counseling in the preceding 12 months) across 51 PFN- and CAN-affiliated churches. The Taro Yamane formula, $n = N / [1 + N(e)^2]$, with N = 5,000 and e = 0.05, gave 370.4, taken as 370; adding 10 percent (37) for anticipated non-response gave 407. Multi-stage sampling was used: all 51 churches identified by geo-mapping, a census of all 102 pastors, and proportionate stratified random selection of 305 members. The instrument was the researcher-developed Cultural Barriers and Pastoral Counseling Effectiveness Questionnaire (CBPCEQ), with 38 items in seven sections and a 5-point scale. All 407 questionnaires were returned complete (100% return rate) because they were administered face to face and collected on the spot; this describes returns among those who accepted a questionnaire, not a response rate among everyone approached. Data were analysed with frequencies, percentages, means, standard deviations, Pearson and Spearman correlations and multiple regression at the 0.05 level of significance.

FINDINGS

All four cultural barriers were endorsed: language differences (M = 4.12, SD = 0.35), cultural stigma (M = 4.07, SD = 0.30), preference for tradition (M = 3.63, SD = 0.28) and cultural beliefs and practices (M = 3.21, SD = 0.27), the weakest. Pastoral counseling was rated effective (M = 4.15, SD = 0.29; at least 98.5% agreement on every item). Strategies to mitigate the barriers received the highest agreement (M = 4.24, SD = 0.40), with training pastors in Kalabari language and culture ranked first (M = 4.29). Correlations with effectiveness were small and positive: cultural beliefs and practices ($r = .11$, $p = .030$; $\rho = .09$, $p = .061$), cultural stigma ($r = .12$, $p = .013$; $\rho = .09$, $p = .081$), preference for tradition ($r = .18$; $\rho = .19$; both $p < .001$), language differences ($r = .28$; $\rho = .35$; both $p < .001$) and strategies ($r = .24$; $\rho = .34$; both $p < .001$). The regression model was significant, $F(5, 401) = 10.95$, $p < .001$, $R = .347$, $R^2 = .120$, adjusted $R^2 = .109$, Durbin-Watson = 1.92, with no multicollinearity (tolerance .77 to .93; VIF 1.07 to 1.30). Only language differences ($\beta = .20$, $p < .001$) and strategies ($\beta = .18$, $p < .001$) were independent predictors.

INTERPRETATION, LIMITS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The positive direction of the relationships is opposite to the theoretical expectation that stronger barriers lower effectiveness. It is explained by the fact that every respondent had already received counseling, that scores clustered at the agreement end of the scale, and that agreement tendency or social desirability may have contributed. Two scales had low reliability (cultural beliefs and practices, $\alpha = .24$; preference for tradition, $\alpha = .53$), so findings on these two constructs are less secure; a sensitivity analysis with shortened scales left the main conclusions unchanged. The study recommends: (1) Kalabari language and cultural-competence training for pastors; (2) community psychoeducation to reduce stigma and a guarantee of confidentiality; (3) culturally consistent involvement of family elders as partners; (4) referral networks between pastoral and clinical services; and (5) combining biblical principles with cultural understanding.

KEYWORDS

Cultural barriers, pastoral counseling effectiveness, Kalabari, language barrier, stigma, Buguma City, CBPCEQ, pastoral training

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2	**Review of related literature** The history of helping in Kalabari society, from pre-colonial systems through the missionary encounter to the rise of Pentecostalism; the four theories and the theological framework; the conceptual framework; current trends in culturally responsive pastoral care; and the research gaps.
3	**Research methodology** Design, location, population, the Taro Yamane sample size and sampling technique, the CBPCEQ instrument, validity and reliability, data collection, analysis and research ethics.
4	**Data presentation and analysis** Who responded, reliability, normality and validity tests, answers to all five research questions, correlation and regression results, hypothesis tests and supplementary analyses.
5	**Discussion of findings** Findings by objective, a combined reading of the correlation and regression results, links to theory and comparison with previous studies.
6	**Summary, conclusion and recommendations** Key findings, conclusion, recommendations for action and further study, contributions to knowledge and limitations.
+	**References and appendices** The reference list, the full CBPCEQ questionnaire, the SPSS data dictionary and the SPSS output.

Who will find it useful

Pastors and church counselors, church leaders, seminary and counseling students, researchers in psychology and theology, and organizations that work with faith communities in Nigeria and elsewhere.

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